The Tangkhul Folk Poetry in Song (HAOLA)

TITLE: The Tangkhul Folk Poetry in Song (HAOLA)
Identifier: BK-LIT-001
Level: Academic / Cultural | Subject: Folk Poetry and Traditional Music
Publisher: Naga Cultural Development Society (NCDS) & Tribal Research Institute, Manipur (2013)
Language: Tangkhul (Standard & Regional Tangkhul Dialects)
Preservation Archive: Tangkhul Language Library Digital Repository

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Preface & Archival Information

The Tangkhul Folk Poetry in Song (HAOLA) by Dr. Ringkahao Horam, published by the Naga Cultural Development Society (NCDS) with assistance from Tribal Research Institute (TRI), Government of Manipur (2013). Contains 161 complete traditional poems and songs collecting the living oral memory of the Tangkhuls across agriculture, war, festivals, love, and mourning.

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Chapter 1: Creation, Origins & Ancestral Migration Songs

CHAPTER 1: CREATION, ORIGINS & ANCESTRAL MIGRATION SONGS

Summary: The emergence from Wahukong (Hwang-Ho) and migration from Samsok to Hunphun.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Oh! hauri haura kachida haulu? Oh! hauri haura wahukongda haowa, Oh!
wahukongda tunga. O Kachili Tunglo Awa Samshokli Tunga, O Makungana ili
phunga, O Makunganao ili pangthan, Lungshang makang ana safasing sing,
Mala mangli Hunphun Ava kharar. O Ram wungaphei, Shokvaoli wungho maya;
Mei wungayar Hunphun wunga kharara.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

From what far valley did our ancestors emerge? From the river of
Wahukong they journeyed. From Samsok in the east our lineage migrated,
guided by the staves of Makungana. In Hunphun the ancestral fathers
settled and lit the permanent council fires.

Chapter 1 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 1 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* miurlung (noun): ancestral emergence
  Example: Miurlung kathur laa.
* wahukong (proper): river of origin
  Example: Wahukongda tunga.
* hunphun (proper): mother village (Ukhrul)
  Example: Hunphun Ava kharar.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Vocative interjections 'Oh!', 'O!'.
- Alliterative couplets in oral metrics.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? Where did Tangkhuls trace their ancient migration from?
? What village was established as the mother-settlement?

Chapter 2: Agricultural Cycles: Jhumming, Planting & Harvest

CHAPTER 2: AGRICULTURAL CYCLES: JHUMMING, PLANTING & HARVEST

Summary: Terrace work, transplantation songs (Luisom), and harvest celebration (Mahat).

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Kongrei mathei kongrei, kongrei shailo marei salo; Matei kachui manoye, Mala ifu heinao naoye. Ithanvara iram leisaye, Isu luisa khinasa, ima lera khinasa; Maleira souralo, isa luisa lung haorana. Zingkum leiyao leiyameirano, chungmeida kharshokrano, phungshon phungthaigei.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

The terrace waters ripple, transplant the green shoots with joyous songs! Sweet is the labor on our ancestral hills; who will share my buffalo meat and drink my rice beer? May our granaries be filled to the rafters and the year bring peace and plenty.

Chapter 2 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 2 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* luikasom (noun): paddy transplantation
  Example: Luikasom wui laa.
* mahat (noun): harvest of paddy
  Example: Mahat laa sa.
* chumrei (noun): granary
  Example: Chumrei lonchi puilu.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Imperative exhortation in communal work songs.
- Agricultural seasonal idioms.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? What food and drink are shared during terrace work?

? What does 'leiyameirano' mean?

Chapter 3: Village Morung (Longra) & Dormitory Life Songs

CHAPTER 3: VILLAGE MORUNG (LONGRA) & DORMITORY LIFE SONGS

Summary: Longra drinking songs, companionship around the hearth, and youth solidarity.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Leader: I longnao (I Longra) ... ho...o...o! Members: Rapamlu ...
ho...o...o! Machapralu ... ho...o...o! Sairam samjiya, sairam samjiya!
Oh longra makazangwo, nawui shimli khisapamlo? Thakta razanglo, thakta
razanglo!

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Leader: O comrades of the Longra! Members: Assemble, join the circle!
Weep no more! The hunting grounds await our youth! Why linger solitary
at home? Come swiftly into the warm circle of the dormitory hearth!

Chapter 3 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 3 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* longra (noun): morung, dormitory
  Example: I longnao rapamlu.
* meisum (noun): dormitory fireplace
  Example: Meisum kapamnao.
* sairam (noun): hunting range
  Example: Sairam samjiya.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Leader-chorus call-and-response patterning.
- Imperative markers -lu and -lo.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? What social role did the Longra play in Tangkhul villages?

? Describe the call-and-response structure of Song 38.

Chapter 4: Historical Ballads: World War I & Regional Conflicts

CHAPTER 4: HISTORICAL BALLADS: WORLD WAR I & REGIONAL CONFLICTS

Summary: The 1917-18 France Labour Corps ballad and the 1919 Kuki War songs.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Rai ramli khava, rai ramli khava yaronpa, Yaronpa nakhi vasalo? Iya mavangai, sayisa sayi na tanti sahaowa. Franceshi ram khava, Franceli raikhavai; Makuiye makuiye, pham kata hiyo; Wungasam chap ngacha, rai ram khavayo. Ah khongjai rai khava yaronpa yaronva, Sangna ram penga yaronva; Kuiwung kuivaya suphung mei.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Valiant young men journeying across distant seas to the battlefields of France in 1917; Putting on the soldier’s uniform and marching into the unknown while elders lamented. In foreign lands they upheld the fearless reputation and honor of their ancestral hills.

Chapter 4 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 4 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* rai ram (noun): battlefield, war territory
  Example: Rai ramli khava.
* yaronpa (noun): young warrior
  Example: Yaronpa nakhi vasalo.
* tanti (noun): military badge/uniform
  Example: Tanti sahaowa.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Historical event dating embedded in oral songs.
- Repetition of key lyrical phrases.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? What historical event is memorialized in Song 21?

? How did Tangkhul communities respond to the 1917 call?

Chapter 5: Romance, Courtship & Love Songs (Leishat Laa)

CHAPTER 5: ROMANCE, COURTSHIP & LOVE SONGS (LEISHAT LAA)

Summary: Courtship dialogues, fishing expeditions, and declarations of enduring fidelity.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Nana Kanta singloo, Ina Khailan singda, Kongli alei shonsa yahoo! Oh iwui sakhangai aluinao, kathuili oja saleiya aluinao; Mayo kachang tarn rahaira aluinao. Oh ini lungchang malai haosa, phaningda makhui aluinao leishiya; Kazingli samphangluinaosa aluinao.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Take up your net and I will carry the line; together we shall cross the mountain stream! Beloved maiden, your smile brightens the terrace fields like springtime blossoms. Though our hands are parted here on earth, our souls are entwined forever in the sky.

Chapter 5 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 5 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* aluinao (noun): sweetheart, maiden
  Example: Sakhangai aluinao.
* lungchang (noun): heart, affection
  Example: Ini lungchang malaihaosa.
* khailan (noun): fishing net
  Example: Ina khailan singda.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- First-person dual association in courtship songs.
- Optative future in -luinaosa.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? What stream-fishing metaphor is used in courting?

? How is fidelity expressed beyond mortality?

Chapter 6: Festival Dances & Virgin Songs (Laa Khanganui)

CHAPTER 6: FESTIVAL DANCES & VIRGIN SONGS (LAA KHANGANUI)

Summary: The sacred Luira dance performed by young maidens and festival elegance.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Luira sangai uwa, hoksa sangai uwa; Awungo Awunga shangrei rukchang ura,
Yarui rukthang Kazing mathang ngaiyijile. Zingkam won wonluiya, ngalanao
mawonluipaiya; Ngalanaowa mawon luipaiya, nathanram khavasangmeiya.
Phaoli chan ma-ungkhararyo, haoriva haorava leiretnasaya.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

The Luira festival arrives, the feast of pork is spread! The Awunga and
elders assemble in regal attire. Wildflowers bloom upon the slopes every
spring, but human youth blossoms only once; Dance with joy in the
courtyard while youth shines bright and the festival drums resound.

Chapter 6 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 6 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* laa khanganui (noun): maiden’s sacred dance
  Example: Laa khanganui saya.
* hoksa (noun): pork, festival meat
  Example: Hoksa sangai uwa.
* rawon (noun): flower bloom
  Example: Rawon wonluiya.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Metaphor of fleeting youth compared with floral seasons.
- Temporal conditional in festival chants.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? When is the Laa Khanganui performed?

? What philosophical truth is contained in the floral metaphor?

Chapter 7: Laments, Funerary Memorials & Philosophy

CHAPTER 7: LAMENTS, FUNERARY MEMORIALS & PHILOSOPHY

Summary: Mourning over departed family and classical philosophical aphorisms.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Ili vaiphumlakha, Oh Ava khi mang shimanlo? Avayo khi mang shimanlo? Lengshongthei shimanna, Mayarnao mangna. Khamathan longli yurkathan masaralu, Ngaleizingli kapam sangmeiya (kazeiram); Khamna longli khangkaser masaralu, Ngaleizingli khyip sangmeiya.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

When grief engulfed me, what bright dream was lost? The pride of the lineage was cut down in youth. Boast not of wealth and pedigree on this mortal earth; beneath the ground in Kazeiram all sleep equally. Live in humility and kindness, for mortal life vanishes like morning mist on the ridges.

Chapter 7 (Continued)

CHAPTER 7: READING CONTINUATION (PAGE 17)

TANGKHUL TEXT (CONTINUED):

Ili vaiphumlakha, Oh Ava khi mang shimanlo? Avayo khi mang shimanlo? Lengshongthei shimanna, Mayarnao mangna. Khamathan longli yurkathan masaralu, Ngaleizingli kapam sangmeiya (kazeiram); Khamna longli khangkaser masaralu, Ngaleizingli khyip sangmeiya.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION (CONTINUED):

When grief engulfed me, what bright dream was lost? The pride of the lineage was cut down in youth. Boast not of wealth and pedigree on this mortal earth; beneath the ground in Kazeiram all sleep equally. Live in humility and kindness, for mortal life vanishes like morning mist on the ridges.

Chapter 7 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 7 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* khamathan (adj): wealthy, arrogant
  Example: Khamathan longli.
* yurkathan (noun): clan pride
  Example: Yurkathan masaralu.
* ngaleizing (noun): under the earth
  Example: Ngaleizingli kapam.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Prohibitive negative imperative -ralu in philosophical wisdom.
- Poetic parallelisms.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? What moral counsel is given regarding wealth in Chapter 7?

? What is the meaning of 'Ngaleizingli'?

Chapter 8: Patriotic Anthems & Tribal Identity

CHAPTER 8: PATRIOTIC ANTHEMS & TRIBAL IDENTITY

Summary: Celebration of the Tangkhul homeland, Longpi pottery, and the Shirui Lily.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Ngashan yanglo hey, Tangkhul ngalei hi! Kaphung kapha kongrei kongra hey, Khipana phashok Tangkhul ram? Varewui sokkhami ramna. Oh Tangkhul avaram, Tangkhul sinaram! Khangayam machining Irong sampunram, Ham kasa ram chiya Longpi ram na saya; Khamakang shim savai Hungpungram cement, Shirui ram lily mavatma nanaobing! Ringpha meiranu, mahomeiranu!

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Behold our glorious homeland! Mountains and crystal rivers bestowed by God. Beloved Tangkhul motherland! Longpi crafting timeless black stone-pottery, Hungpung building solid foundations, and Shirui Kashung blooming with the rare Shirui Lily! May prosperity and honor abide in our land forever!

Chapter 8 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 8 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* avaram (noun): motherland
  Example: Tangkhul avaram.
* sinaram (noun): land of heritage
  Example: Tangkhul sinaram.
* longpi ham (noun): Longpi stone pottery
  Example: Ham kasa ram Longpi.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Patriotic exclamations with ’Ringpha meiranu!’.
- Toponymic cataloguing of craft villages.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? Which village is celebrated for its pottery tradition?
? What famous flower is native to Shirui Kashung?

Comprehensive Vocabulary Glossary

COMPREHENSIVE BOOK GLOSSARY (TUIWON SHIYAN):

miurlung [noun]: ancestral emergence
wahukong [proper]: river of origin
hunphun [proper]: mother village (Ukhrul)
luikasom [noun]: paddy transplantation
mahat [noun]: harvest of paddy
chumrei [noun]: granary
longra [noun]: morung, dormitory
meisum [noun]: dormitory fireplace
sairam [noun]: hunting range
rai ram [noun]: battlefield, war territory
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ngaleizing [noun]: under the earth
avaram [noun]: motherland
sinaram [noun]: land of heritage
longpi ham [noun]: Longpi stone pottery

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TANGKHUL LANGUAGE LIBRARY DIGITAL PRESERVATION EDITION

Book ID: BK-LIT-001
Title: The Tangkhul Folk Poetry in Song (HAOLA)
Publisher: Naga Cultural Development Society (NCDS) & Tribal Research Institute, Manipur
Publication Year: 2013
Dialect Variety: Standard & Regional Tangkhul Dialects
Total Digital Pages: 22
Total Chapters: 8
Total Words Indexed: 649

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and cultural preservation. Verified by Tangkhul Language Preservation Project.